

COURTSHIP AND MARRIAGE

TEXT: Revelation 19:8 *“And to her was granted that she should be arrayed in fine linen, clean and white: for the fine linen is the righteousness of saints.”*

INTRO: Today is Valentine’s Day. Happy Valentine’s Day to you all.

I want to use the steps of a Jewish wedding to challenge each of us about our relationships with our spouses as well as our relationship to Jesus.

At the time of Christ, there were Seven stages to a Jewish wedding:

I. THE CONTRACT

The Contract or legal covenant was an agreement by which the young man proposed marriage.

Any young man could show up with a contract, but typically, the marriages were arranged and the contracts drawn up by the parents long before the youngsters ever got the news. (I would like to bring back this custom before my Grandchildren get married)

Jesus is the groom and we are the selected bride. We should love our spouses as “*Christ loved the church, and gave Himself for it.*”

The Church is called the “*Bride of Christ*” in the New Testament for good reason.

It is The Church who has a covenant relationship with the One Who forgives sins - Jesus Christ.

The Old Covenant (Law), which was given to Moses was totally inflexible. But the New Covenant is a relationship based on LOVE, not fear – This is a matter of the heart!

The relationship between a man and woman should be based on love, not fear. No one should be walking around on egg shells!

The New Covenant is signed, dated, sealed and delivered.

II. THE PRICE

The family of each bride had a price for the dowry of their daughter, and the prospective bridegroom was expected to pay it.

Jesus paid the ultimate price. We should love our spouse in the same way.

The bride's father received money, in effect, because he had raised a daughter so wisely and well, that someone desired to marry her. The Price that was placed on the daughter allowed the father to recover some of his prior losses, and even make a profit on the marriage of his daughter, to a wealthy groom. (I need to send an invoice to Jeremy)

The Price also served as "*earnest money*", which is a valuable aspect of any legal transaction to this very day.

The Price is obvious - Jesus Christ came to offer Himself upon the Cross of Calvary for our redemption. There was never a greater price paid for a bride than Jesus Christ paid for the Church!

We should be willing to make whatever sacrifice is necessary for our spouse.

III. THE CUP

In those days it was traditional for the groom to pour a Cup of wine for his intended bride, and then he would propose a toast to the audience. This served also to establish that both parties agreed to the terms of the contract – this became a legal and binding agreement.

Matthew 26:27-28 (NKJV) “*Then He took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying, “Drink from it, all of you. ²⁸ For this is*

My blood of the new covenant, which is shed for many for the remission of sins.” This was a portrait of Jesus drinking the Cup of covenant with His Bride. His Blood is what has made us His bride, and sealed the Marriage Covenant.

His blood was shed for the remission of sins, fulfilling Jeremiah’s announcement of the New Covenant - The covenant would not just roll sin’s ahead, it would Forgive Sin!!! The New Testament that we hold in front of us, is OUR copy of this Marriage Contract. We have been bought with a Price - The Blood of Jesus! The Apostle Peter said, ***“We were not redeemed with corruptible things such as silver and gold; but with the PRECIOUS BLOOD OF JESUS!”***

We should be willing to shed our blood, if necessary, for our spouse.

IV. THE DEPARTURE OF THE BRIDEGROOM

Tradition says that once the engagement had been agreed to by all parties, the groom would go back to his home for an undisclosed period of time. When he made his exit, he would say something on the order of, *"I go to prepare a place for you."*

The goal of every spouse should be to build a better life for their companion. We should be intent each day on improving their lives, not making each day more miserable.

Before Jesus left earth for Heaven, He said, John 14:1-3 (NKJV) ***"Let not your heart be troubled; you believe in God, believe also in Me. ² In My Father's house are many mansions; if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you.³ And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and receive you to Myself; that where I am, there you may be also."***

The Lord is now preparing the Bridal Chamber for the Church.

Like the Jewish bride, we must watch and wait for His return - For “*We know not the day or the hour of His return.*”

In the meantime, let us keep our veil on, as a symbol of our engagement - our testimony of betrothal. Let us not commit adultery with the world, for the Bridegroom is coming.

V. THE RETURN OF THE BRIDEGROOM

When the bridegroom left his prospective bride's home, he then returned to his father's house to build his bride a "*Bridal Chamber*" - A little mansion - For their honeymoon and future home.

During this period of time, which usually took between 1-2 years, the bride would spend her time gathering her things and making herself ready for the bridegrooms return. One thing she was to do was to keep her veil on wherever she went. This let everyone know she was engaged, and also kept her in a state of readiness, should the bridegroom return unexpectedly.

As a matter of fact, the groom did not know when he would come back! Only his father knew.

The bride was literally "*Stolen*" by her bridegroom! Once the engagement was agreed upon, the bridegroom could literally appear at any time. The only thing necessary for the reappearance of the bridegroom was that he had made all things ready for the bride.

Tradition says that the groom usually came for his bride in the middle of the night, to seize her out of her bed.

She did not know when or where she was going, and only with lamp in hand could she be led along by her groom.

We should keep our lamps (Spiritual lives) full of oil, trimmed and burning!

Jewish brides were Stolen, if you will, in the night, by their perspective grooms. It was customary that the Groom announce with a

shout when he was near the bride's home, so that she would momentarily realize that her groom had come for her.

Once the bridegroom arrived and stole his bride, she became his total responsibility.

We should see the happiness and comfort of our spouses as our sole responsibility.

1 Thessalonians 4:16-17 (NKJV) ***“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷ Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸ Therefore comfort one another with these words.”*** 1 Cor. 15:51-57 (NKJV)

“Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵² in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the

dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³ For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴ So when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.”

VI. THE BRIDAL CHAMBER

Once the bride had been stolen away by the bridegroom, the bride and groom would go to the bridal chamber and shut the door behind them.

The best-man would stay near the door until the marriage had been consummated. Once the marriage was consummated, the best man would let the other guests know that the wedding party was about to begin.

The bride and the groom would remain in the chamber for up to seven days, at last emerging for the marriage supper.

Marriage partners have a responsibility toward each other to make sure the physical and sexual needs of their partner is taken care of. Once you get married, ***“Your body is not your own.”*** Once you get married, you owe your spouse, ***“Due benevolence.”***

When Jesus returns certain things will happen on earth and in heaven for the next 7 years.

The Judgment Seat of Christ, which will be the reward of the righteous, will occur in heaven while the great tribulation will be getting into full swing on the earth.

This can be likened to the removing of the Veil from the Bride, which occurred during the Honeymoon! All of our Secrets will be made known at the Judgment Seat of Christ! It is here that the bride of Christ will be rewarded for faithfulness. ***“Well done, you good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a few things, so I will make you ruler over many things.”***

VII. THE MARRIAGE SUPPER

This is the last aspect of the Jewish Custom of Marriage - The Marriage Supper. This is what we call the wedding reception, in effect, a banquet for the newly married couple.

The Church will be arrayed in white. Revelation 19:7-8 "***Fine Linen, Clean, and White: for the fine linen is the righteousness of the saints.***"

After the marriage supper, the Bride and Groom would typically leave his father's house and go to the housing that the groom had arranged for them.

This speaks of the finality of the relationship.

Our marriages should be:

- For better or worse...
- For richer or poorer...
- In sickness and in health...
- So long as we both shall live...

I'm married to Jesus and it is forever. I'm married to Susan and it is forever.